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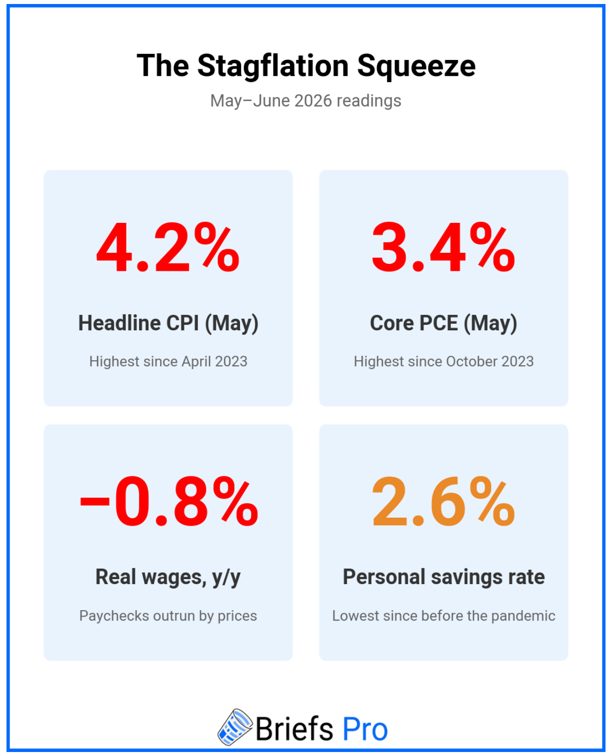
WEALTH PRESERVATION

July 2026 Report

There's a term floating around Wall Street that hasn't shown up in about 50 years: Stagflation.

In English: Stagflation happens when prices keep climbing while the economy slows down.

As of mid-2026, the U.S. isn't just flirting with stagflation - it's in it. To see how, follow the money through a typical American's budget this year:



- Inflation (CPI) hit 4.2% in May, its highest point since April 2023 - that means higher prices from the pump to the grocery store.
- Adjusted for inflation, the average paycheck shrank 0.8% over the past year - so the average worker is making less, too.
- The savings rate slid to 2.6%, and consumer confidence just posted its second-lowest score on record.

Meanwhile, the Fed's preferred measure, core PCE - which removes food and energy prices - also hit 3.4%, a near three-year high.

The bottom line: Prices are rising, paychecks aren't keeping up, and the economy is slowing - all at once.

That squeeze doesn't stop at the kitchen table - it breaks the investor playbook, too.

Normally, this is when investors hide out in long-term Treasury bonds. Not this time.

Washington is on pace for a $1.9 trillion deficit - and to cover it, the government has to issue a flood of new Treasuries. More supply means higher yields to find buyers, and when yields rise, the price of the bonds people already own falls.

Put simply: The old safe haven is losing value right when investors need it most.

All that sounds rough - but remember, money is always moving, and that movement is creating what we have identified as a **Broad Market Shift:**

Families can't escape rising prices, but investors can own the companies collecting them.

With the old bond shelter leaking, wealth protection is moving toward gold - and toward businesses whose cash flows climb with inflation and whose demand never quits.

It's defense that holds up even if rates never come down or if we stay in stagflation.

One thing to know upfront: This report isn't hunting market-beating returns. It's hunting names built to hold their value if the economy gets worse, which protects your wealth.

How we got here: This shift traces back to two supply shocks.

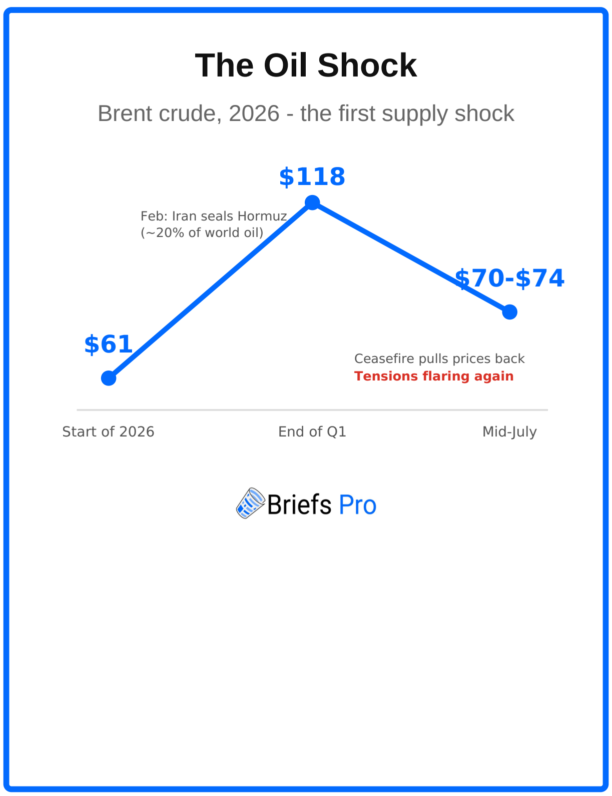
The first was oil. In February, after a U.S.-Israeli strike, Iran sealed off the Strait of Hormuz - the waterway carrying about 20% of the world's oil.

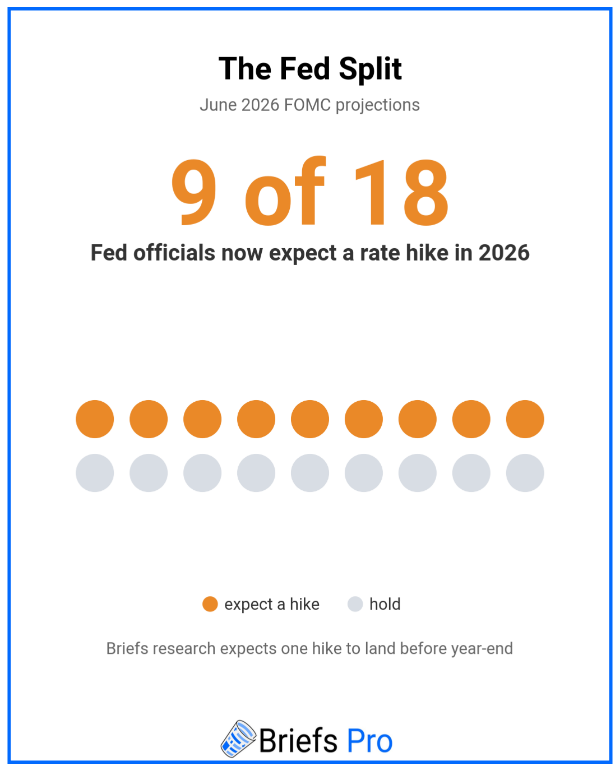
Brent crude rocketed from $61 a barrel to $118 in three months. A ceasefire pulled prices near $70, but by mid-July the conflict is heating back up.

The second was tariffs, which tacked about 0.8 percentage points onto core inflation.

Those shocks lit a fire, which is spreading. Kevin Warsh, the Fed's new chair, turned hawkish in June - in simple terms, he's leaning toward rate hikes in the future.

Now 9 of 18 officials expect a hike this year - our team believes one lands before year-end. So the Fed is fighting prices, not rescuing markets.





Our analysts saw this and went hunting for the two names below: One that gains when the dollar loses value, and one that earns through inflation with demand that never quits.

Below, we break down what's happening and the two stocks our analysts are adding to our Wealth Preservation Portfolio.

FRANCO-NEVADA (FNV)

Franco-Nevada is the gold hedge - minus the shovels.

What's happening? When bonds can't play defense, investors reach for a store of value no government can print: Gold.

History shows that gold prices actually grow during stagflation, and demand is already rising. Central banks scooped up 244 tonnes of the metal in Q1 2026 alone.

- In July 2026, Poland announced it has bought 82 tonnes of gold this year.

Major banks can't settle on a gold price - JPMorgan alone has changed its target several times this year, most recently to around $4,500 an ounce by the fourth quarter of 2026.

Franco-Nevada may be a potential opportunity to ride that wave without owning a single mine.

How? Franco-Nevada is a royalty company - it hands miners cash upfront, then collects a slice of their sales for years to come.

It gets paid off the top line. So rising fuel, labor, and equipment costs are the miners' problem, not Franco-Nevada's.

That structure shields it from the very inflation this whole report is about. The model shows up in its numbers:

- Profit margins (EBITDA) above 90%.
- Zero debt on the books.

Central Banks Are Hoarding Gold

Official-sector demand keeps the bid under the metal

244 tonnes

net central-bank gold buying

Q1 2026 alone

82 tonnes

Poland's gold purchases in 2026, announced July

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The Hedge Is On Sale

Gold and its lowest-risk proxy - both marked down from 2026 highs

SPOT GOLD

$4,133

/oz - about 25% below its 2026 high (~$5,500)

FRANCO-NEVADA (FNV)

-27%

from its 52-week high

52-week high: $285.67 · Last: $208.09

Trading below its 50- and 200-day moving averages

Royalty model: 90%+ EBITDA margins, zero debt

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There's also a setup on the price side. Gold has pulled back about 25% from its 2026 high near $5,500 an ounce - and shares of Franco-Nevada trade about 27% below their own high right alongside it.

What does that mean for defensive investors? The pullback marked the hedge itself down too - defense at a discount. That's why investors may want to keep a close eye on this one.

Exit Trigger: This hedge could lose value if core inflation stays under 2.5% for a few months, the Fed turns friendly, or central banks stop buying gold. A slide in gold under about $3,700 would be another cue to step back.

WASTE MANAGEMENT (WM)

If inflation stays sticky around 3% while demand weakens, Waste Management was almost built for that exact mix.

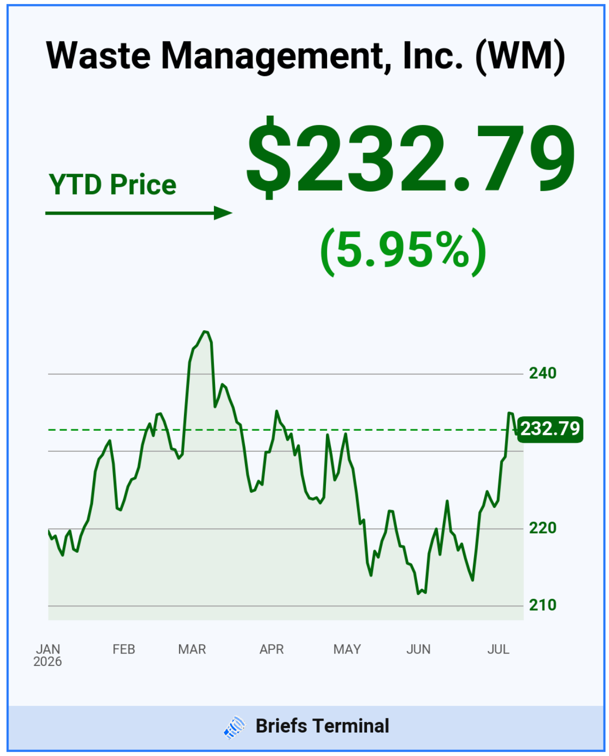
Its contracts with cities and businesses include automatic price bumps tied to inflation - and it's one of the biggest waste companies in the country.

When prices rise, WM's prices rise with it - by contract, no haggling required.

Demand doesn't budge either, because homes and businesses take out the trash in booms and busts alike.

Think of WM as a toll booth on garbage: The traffic never stops, and the toll adjusts itself for inflation. That combo has produced some steady results:

- 23 straight years of dividend increases.
- Free cash flow (the money left after running the business) that keeps growing.



The catch? Stability isn't cheap. WM trades at a premium price and yields about 1.6% - all because it has such steady earnings and focuses on increasing shareholder value.

Exit Trigger: Watch for WM's price hikes lagging its own costs for two straight quarters, a lasting drop in trash volumes, or a broken dividend streak. Shares stuck under about $222 - the stock's 200-day average - would also raise a flag that it may be time for investors to throw out this opportunity.

Positioning

These names don't rise and fall for the same reasons - and that's by design:

- Franco-Nevada follows gold and the value of money itself.
- Waste Management follows contracts tied to real-world inflation.

If one of the ideas breaks, it won't take the other down with it.

Timing matters here, too. Waste Management trades near its 52-week high, with Franco-Nevada the one already marked down.

That's why the research favors spreading buys out over time instead of jumping in all at once.

Risks We're Watching

One cost to know upfront: This basket is built to stay stable, not to beat a booming market. If inflation falls and the economy starts growing again, these names will likely trail the S&P 500.

Think of that like an insurance premium: You pay it whether or not the storm shows up. These stocks are suited for a prolonged period of stagflation - they're not built to outgrow the overall market.

The real risk is a deep drawdown in the names themselves:

- Franco-Nevada could post real losses if gold keeps giving back its gains.
- Waste Management trades at a premium price, which leaves little cushion in a broad selloff.

In a scenario where there is a recession paired with high inflation, stocks and long-term bonds fall together, and unemployment climbs above 5.5%.

This research wrapped before June's inflation data arrived. Those numbers will either back up the sticky-inflation call or push against it.

The Takeaway

Forecasters keep shifting their worry toward 2027 on stagflation. That's when debt payments, credit card balances, and companies needing new loans all pile up at once.

Our research treats this as a story that runs through the end of 2027, not a quick trade.

Flashback: In the late 1970s, the Fed waited too long to fight inflation.

- Winning that fight took interest rates near 20% and two recessions in a row - a mistake today's Fed clearly wants to avoid.

A few things worth watching from here:

- The next core PCE reports, which will show whether service prices stay stubborn.
- The Fed meetings in October and December, where a hike would most likely land.

- The Iran ceasefire, and whether oil keeps flowing through the Strait of Hormuz.
- Any sudden, messy jump in long-term Treasury yields.

Stagflation is going to sting consumers - but for investors, it's actually creating an opportunity to preserve wealth, whether things improve or get worse.

- Briefs Finance Team

*The Briefs Finance Team often invests in the same stocks and assets we cover.

Why? Because we believe in practicing what we preach (and preaching what we practice).

But keep in mind: We're not financial advisors. Everything we provide is for education. You've got to do your own due diligence and think about what makes sense for your own financial situation. Investing has risks.

You are never guaranteed to make money when you invest, you might even lose money. If you're looking for personalized financial advice, we highly recommend speaking with a licensed financial advisor.

Our mission? It's simple - to help you be better with money.

Included interviews have been edited for length and clarity.